



▲ HOOK GUN

Date	c.1500
Origin	Germany
Barrel	39in (99cm)
Caliber	.90in (23mm)

An improvement over earlier hand-cannon, although still undeniably simple, this hook gun consists of little more than an iron barrel fitted to a wooden stave, the stave being held under the armpit to stabilize the gun during firing. The wooden stave would evolve into the shoulder stock. The front hook beneath the barrel could be placed on a stable object to improve accuracy.

Hook for stabilizing barrel



Stave



Iron tiller to aim gun

Vent hole



▲ IRON HANDGUN

Date	c.1500
Origin	Netherlands
Barrel	28in (71cm)
Caliber	.90in (23mm)

This early handgun does not have a wooden stock, but instead features a long iron tiller running out from the rear of the barrel. The weight and awkward shape of the weapon must have made it difficult to handle in the absence of a front support.

Foresight

Barrel

▲ EARLY MATCHLOCK HARQUEBUS

Date	c.1560
Origin	Germany
Barrel	29½in (75cm)
Caliber	.59in (15mm)

This match-fired harquebus resembles a more modern firearm because its stock covers most of its body, a trend that would continue in muskets and other firearms. Note also the increased expectations of accuracy indicated by the front and rear sights, although the proportions of the gun (it weighed 50lb/22.7kg) must have affected accurate handling.



FULL VIEW